Conf42 Observability 2026

AI Coded It, AI Shipped It, Who Owns It?

How do we manage incidents when AI writes, and fixes, most of the code.

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A NIGHT IN THE NEAR FUTURE

03:47 25/06/2027



The pager fires
A SEV-1 nobody has seen before. Revenue is bleeding.



The agent already had a go
It ran, retried, and gave up. The easy fixes were never yours to make.



You open a codebase you've never read
Most of it was written by agents, for agents. Little context, fewer reps than you'd have had one year ago.



The uncomfortable question
When the agent can't, who can — and are they still ready?

WHERE WE'RE GOING

Preparing for the next era of on-call



The ground is moving

What's changing?
Why it matters now.



We are not the first to face this change

How other industries kept expertise alive under automation.



Let’s build our new future. Together

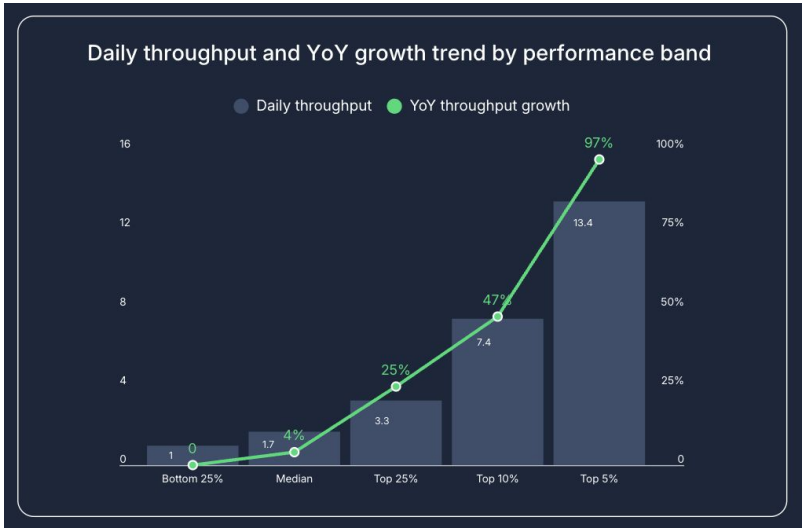
What tools do you need?
How can you prepare?

01

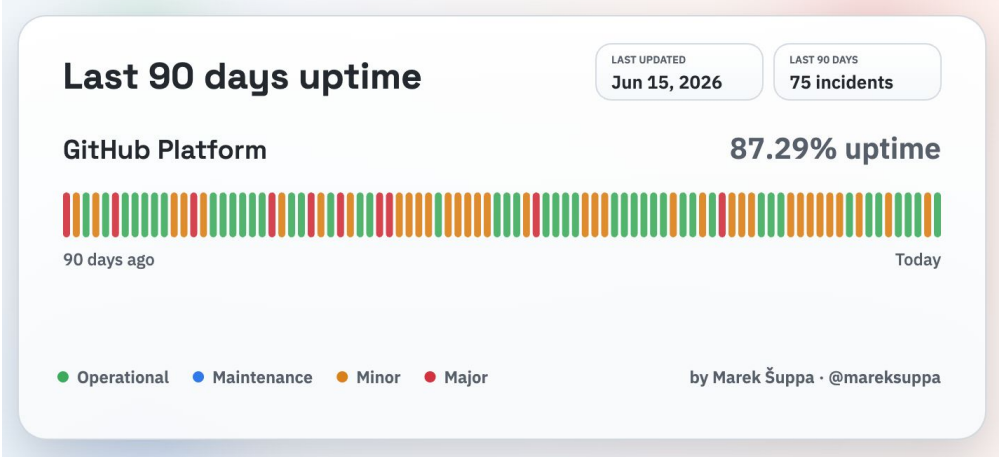
WHY

The ground is moving.

The industry is changing. Fast.

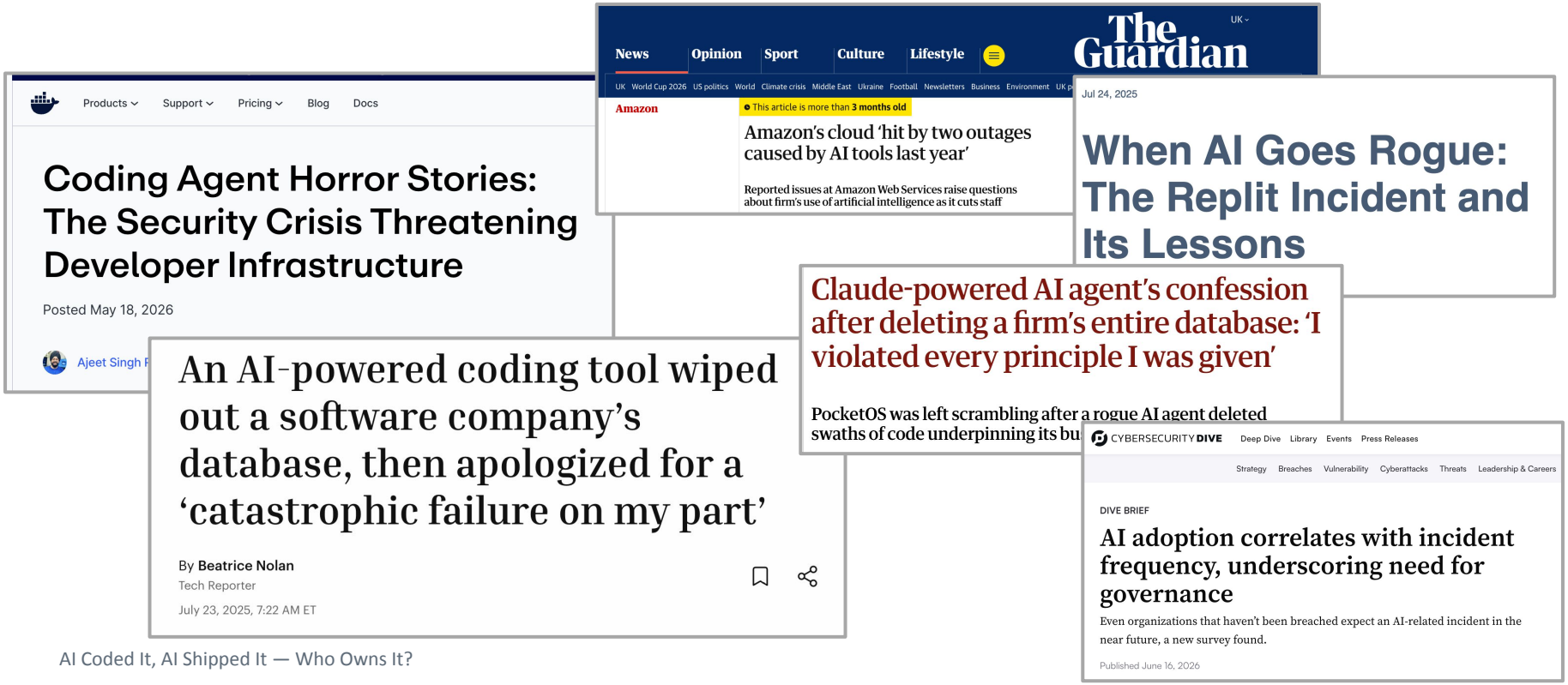


CircleCI State of Software Delivery 2026



The Missing GitHub Status Page

AI induced incidents are happening



“Code It, Ship It, Own It” PagerDuty’s mantra is breaking



***Code It:* increasingly written by agents**
Humans review more code than they author, across more repos than anyone has read.



***Ship It:* humans will move out of the loop**
Agents open, merge, and deploy. Velocity climbs; familiarity falls.



***Own It:* teams own more services, with less oversight**
You're accountable for systems you didn't write and can't fully hold in your head.

The 3rd phase of DevOps



Siloed Dev/Ops

Devs threw code over the wall.
Ops carried the pager for it.





DevOps

You build it, you run it.
Ownership and feedback loops tightened.





AgentOps

Agents write the code.
Agents manage the Ops.





Siloed Agents/Ops

Agents write and ship the bulk.
Humans manage the sprawl.

The Upcoming Challenge



Code deployed at AI speed
More code deployed, humans have less context.



Agents manage minor incidents
Humans lose the training.



We meet the big one cold
Less context, less recent practice, higher stakes. This exactly when we can least afford it.

Expertise doesn't survive on its own



Automation takes the routine work
The same work that, as a side effect, used to keep skills warm.



The automation paradox
The more reliable the automation, the rustier, and rarer, the humans who can do it are.



So practice has to be engineered
Industries that got this right made skill maintenance deliberate, not incidental.

02

HOW

We are not the first to face this change.



On March 3, 1969 the United States Navy established an elite school for the top one percent of its pilots. Its purpose was to teach the lost art of aerial combat and to insure that the handful of men who graduated were the best fighter pilots in the world.

They succeeded.

Today, the Navy calls it Fighter Weapons School.
The flyers call it:

TOP GUN

Civil aviation has done this already



Manual era

Pilots hand-flew everything.
Skill was a daily by-product.





Autopilot

Automation took the cruise.
Manual skills quietly eroded.





The reckoning

Accidents traced to crews out of practice when automation quit.

Sound familiar? Swap “pilot” for “SRE” and “autopilot” for “agent.”

The fix:
Practice is mandated, not hoped for



Recurrent simulator time
Regular, scheduled sessions in realistic failure scenarios — for everyone, not just rookies.

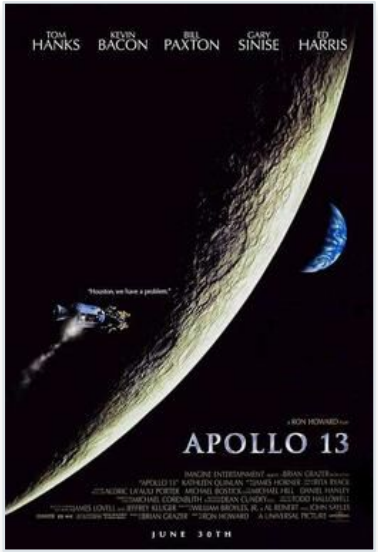


Required manual segments
Crews must hand-fly portions of real flights to keep core skills live.

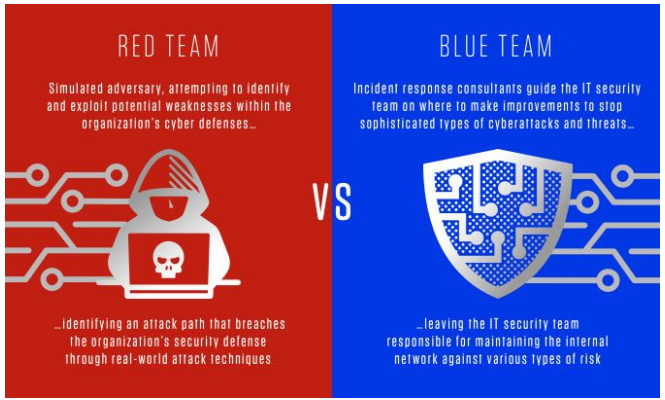


Standardised, reviewed scenarios
Training targets the failures that actually bite, refreshed from incident data.

The pattern repeats…







SREs need simulator time, too



Reactive incident response isn't training
Waiting for the big one to “stay sharp” is the strategy that's failing in the cockpit.



Make practice routine and deliberate
Scheduled, realistic, and aimed at the failures that actually hurt.

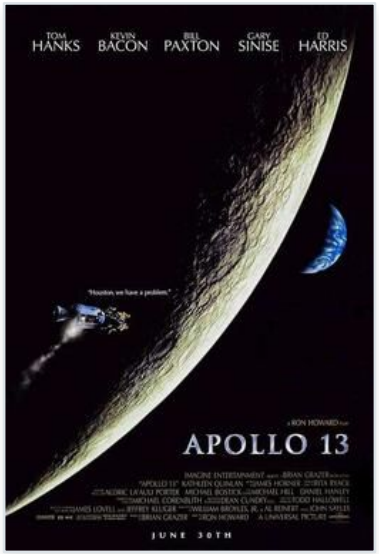


Learn from all incidents, not just the bad ones
Near misses often contain more information that actual failures.



Readiness becomes a property you maintain
Not a thing you hope is still there at 03:47.

… but practice isn’t always enough.







03

WHAT NEXT

Let’s build our new future. Together.

Two halves of the same answer



Better tooling

- Surface context faster
- Use incident history to guide training
- Agents designed to take load *and* assist



Sharper people

- Work fluently with agents
- Practice in low-stakes scenarios
- Know how the tools fail!

*Neither alone is enough. Without the right tools **and** practised people it will still fail badly at 03:47.*

Building the right SRE agent



Autopilot

- Takes routine, well-understood incidents end-to-end
- Frees humans from low-value toil



Copilot

- Assists on complex incidents — context, options, actions
- Human stays in command and accountable

The goal isn't to replace the human, it's to keep the humans for when they are needed, and equip them to succeed.

Train effectively

Based on your incidents
Patterns of what breaks, how it's resolved, and where hu

Surface where the AI struggles
Flag the incident classes agents handle poorly, these are

Learn your tools
How they work, what they are good at, and how they fai

Expect black swans
What could possibly go wrong? How to handle that com



What can you do tomorrow morning?

What segments can you fly manually?



Use agents to read, not just write

Drive coding agents to navigate and explain unfamiliar codebases — build the skill before you need it.



Rehearse in low-stakes scenarios

Run game days and drills with the AI in the loop, while the cost of fumbling is near zero.



Learn how agents fail

Know where agents confidently go wrong, so you can spot it fast under pressure.

How can you prepare for the big one?

What is your flight simulator?



Red teaming: game days & chaos engineering

Deliberately inject realistic failure and let people practise the response.



AI-in-the-loop incident drills

Rehearse the exact hand-off: agent tries, agent fails, human takes command.



Target the scenarios that bite

Pull drill content from real incident history, prioritise the failures you actually see, verify against the unexpected.

Embrace our new ownership model



Shared between humans and agents
Agents own the routine; humans own judgement, escalation and accountability.



Organizations engineer the practice in
Readiness is a deliberate program, not a hope it sticks.



“Own It” becomes a conscious choice
Reliability in the agentic era is something teams actively decide to maintain.

Code It. Ship It. Own It.

The agents will *Code It* and *Ship It*.

You will still *Own It*. Especially at 03:47.

Are you ready?